

# U1L6SP — Text Supplement

## Prophecy, Choice, and Consequence

Two scenes for close reading; the whole play remains available

### How to use this supplement

You may use **anything from the play** in your paper: a line, action, choice, image, or consequence. The passages below are not the only acceptable evidence. They are lines worth focusing on because they let you examine what the prophecy says, what Macbeth considers, and what he knows before he acts.

You do not need the internet or another source. Quote exact words when they are printed here. You may accurately paraphrase other events you remember from watching the play.

### Passage 1: Act 1, Scene 3 — After the Witches Speak

**Context:** The witches have greeted Macbeth as Thane of Glamis, Thane of Cawdor, and future king. Messengers then confirm that Macbeth has been named Thane of Cawdor. One prediction has come true; the prediction that he will be king remains unfulfilled.

**Banquo:** But 'tis strange:

And oftentimes, to win us to our harm,  
The instruments of darkness tell us truths,  
Win us with honest trifles, to betray's  
In deepest consequence.

**Macbeth:** Two truths are told,  
As happy prologues to the swelling act  
Of the imperial theme. . . .  
This supernatural soliciting  
Cannot be ill, cannot be good: if ill,  
Why hath it given me earnest of success,  
Commencing in a truth? I am Thane of Cawdor:  
If good, why do I yield to that suggestion  
Whose horrid image doth unfix my hair  
And make my seated heart knock at my ribs,  
Against the use of nature? Present fears  
Are less than horrible imaginings.  
My thought, whose murder yet is but fantastical,  
Shakes so my single state of man  
That function is smother'd in surmise,  
And nothing is but what is not.

**Macbeth:** If chance will have me king, why, chance may crown me,  
Without my stir.

### Words in context

- **honest trifles:** small truths;
- **prologues:** introductions or opening parts;
- **soliciting:** prompting or tempting;
- **earnest:** a pledge or first sign of something promised;
- **fantastical:** existing in imagination;
- **stir:** action or effort.

**As you choose evidence:** Notice what the witches actually predict, what Banquo warns, what Macbeth imagines, and what Macbeth says about acting. Decide for yourself what those differences prove.

## Passage 2: Act 1, Scene 7 — Macbeth Considers the Murder

**Context:** Duncan is Macbeth's king, kinsman, and guest. Macbeth is considering whether to murder him. Alone, Macbeth thinks through possible consequences, his obligations to Duncan, and what is pushing him toward the deed.

**Macbeth:** If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well  
It were done quickly: if the assassination  
Could trammel up the consequence, and catch  
With his surcease success; that but this blow  
Might be the be-all and the end-all here,  
But here, upon this bank and shoal of time,  
We'd jump the life to come. But in these cases  
We still have judgment here; that we but teach  
Bloody instructions, which, being taught, return  
To plague the inventor: this even-handed justice  
Commends the ingredients of our poison'd chalice  
To our own lips.  
He's here in double trust;  
First, as I am his kinsman and his subject,  
Strong both against the deed; then, as his host,  
Who should against his murderer shut the door,  
Not bear the knife myself.  
Besides, this Duncan  
Hath borne his faculties so meek, hath been  
So clear in his great office, that his virtues  
Will plead like angels, trumpet-tongued, against  
The deep damnation of his taking-off.  
I have no spur  
To prick the sides of my intent, but only  
Vaulting ambition, which o'erleaps itself  
And falls on the other.

### Words in context

- **trammel up:** catch, contain, or prevent from spreading;
- **surcease:** death;
- **judgment here:** consequences or justice in this life;
- **double trust:** more than one strong obligation;
- **faculties:** powers and duties of office;
- **taking-off:** killing;
- **spur:** something that drives action;
- **intent:** purpose or plan.

### The rest of the play is available to you

You may connect these lines to any later consequence or choice you remember. Possibilities include Macbeth's rule after Duncan's death, Banquo's murder, the attack on Macduff's family, the later apparitions, the branches from Birnam Wood, and Macbeth's final encounter with Macduff. These are reminders, not required evidence and not conclusions.

If you use a later event, explain how it helps test your claim. You may paraphrase the event accurately; do not invent a quotation from memory.